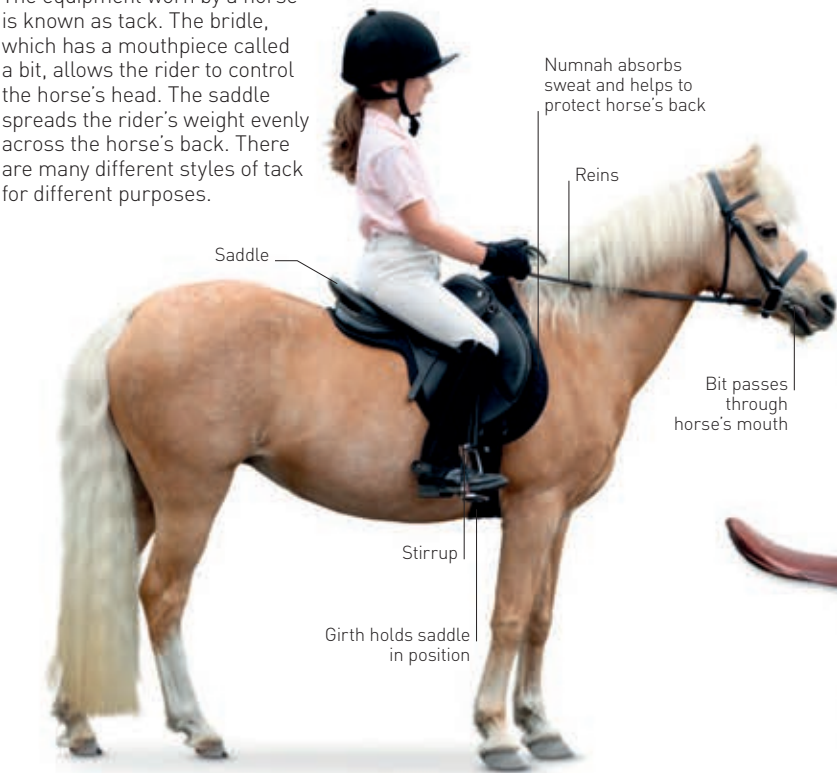


Horse riding

There are many ways to enjoy riding a horse, from playing team games and jumping over obstacles to going for a quiet canter in the countryside. Learning how to look after and handle a horse safely and correctly is part of becoming a good rider.

TACK

The equipment worn by a horse is known as tack. The bridle, which has a mouthpiece called a bit, allows the rider to control the horse's head. The saddle spreads the rider's weight evenly across the horse's back. There are many different styles of tack for different purposes.



RIDING GEAR

A safety hat or helmet is the most important part of a rider's clothing. Boots should have a low heel to stop the feet from slipping through the stirrups. Chaps (leggings) worn over riding trousers or jodhpurs protect the lower legs.



PUTTING ON A SADDLE

It is important to know how to put on a saddle correctly. A badly positioned saddle can hurt a horse's back and be unsafe for the rider. Both before and after mounting, the rider should check that the girth (the strap that goes under the horse's belly) is tight enough.



1 POSITION THE SADDLE
Place the saddle pad or numnah and saddle further forwards than the final position. Move both backwards together.



2 PICK UP GIRTH
Bring down the girth on the far side and pick up the end from the near side. Make sure it is not twisted.



3 FASTEN BUCKLES
Buckle the girth to the straps on the saddle. Pull it tight but without wrinkling the horse's skin.

GROOMING TOOLS

There are various specially designed tools for grooming horses. They include a stiff "dandy" brush and a rubber curry comb for cleaning off mud, softer brushes for removing dust and scurf, and a pick for dislodging dirt from hoofs.



FEEDING A HORSE

The natural food of horses is grass, but a hard-working horse needs more. Extra foodstuffs include hay for fibre, grains such as oats, and nutritious pellets and mixes.

